



Military money

The Vietnam War was the last war to use the Military Payment Certificate program, which tried to prevent local economies from being destabilized by an influx of US dollars.

Fun and games

As the years passed, bases became ever more elaborate, necessitating all the services—water treatment, garbage collection, fire protection—of modern US cities. Construction priorities shifted from housing and services to recreational facilities intended to boost troop morale.

Support personnel on larger bases often did regular shifts in offices, in warehouses, or on flight lines, leaving hours of off-duty time to fill. To provide entertainment—and also prevent mischief such as drug use or going absent without leave (AWOL)—commanders authorized the construction of theaters, craft shops, education centers, libraries, athletics courts, and swimming pools. Alcohol consumption was rampant among American troops, with more than 2,000 open mess clubs (unit-run bars) in South Vietnam at the system's peak.

Meanwhile, the expansion of electricity and broadcast media across the country enabled men to improve their barracks with simple pleasures such as electric fans, hot plates, and radios. Shopping at the local post exchange (PX), or placing an order in the Pacific Mail-Order System (PACEX) catalog for delivery back home, enabled military personnel to acquire souvenirs of their war experience—handicrafts, watches, cameras, jewelry, and even American-made cars—that helped to balance the negatives of spending a year in a war zone.

“Most of the time you didn’t know you were **in a war.”**

WILLIAM R. UPTON, IN *PIZZA AND MORTARS: BA-MUOI-BA AND BODY BAGS*, 2003